



Nomura Quant Insights

Global Markets Research

18 May 2026

Cross-asset - Japan

US tech skew suggests 100% probability of reversal: Will higher rates trigger an AI stock correction?

Focus on breakeven points in Nvidia results / Pause in AI-driven market and rebound in value stocks / Concerns among bank stock investors about yen bonds

Tech skew suggests broader reversal / suggests 100% probability of AI stock reversal since 2023 / All triggers have been macro events / Importance of US interest rates

SOX fell sharply last Friday. Compared to the 18 straight days of gains through late April, upward momentum now appears restrained. With earnings forecasts continuing to grow, it looks as though investors have started to become more concerned about crowding than fundamentals. The option skew in the Magnificent Seven (the difference in implied volatility between puts and calls) turned negative last Thursday for the first time since October 2025 (*Figure 1*). A decline in this skew tends to push down future returns on US equities. Moreover, the option skew in tech stocks ("tech skew") has fallen sharply, nearly reaching its historic low (*Figure 2*). Since 2023, when the AI-driven market began, the tech skew has only fallen below 0.05 (excluding the present) in March and July 2024 and October 2025. In all of these periods, a market reversal occurred within roughly three weeks (*Figure 3*).

Interestingly, none of these reversals were triggered by company-specific catalysts, but by macroeconomic events. From late March through mid-April 2024, 10yr UST yields rose above the psychologically important 4.5% level in response to upside surprises in CPI data for March. Rate cut expectations increased in July in response to lower-than-expected CPI data for June. Tech stocks, which had already seen an increase in crowding, did not benefit from lower yields; instead, capital quickly rotated into Russell, which had previously lagged but caught up thanks to renewed economic optimism. The October 2025 FOMC meeting brought a hawkish surprise. While the Fed cut rates, it discouraged market expectations for a rate cut in December, which had been seen as almost a foregone conclusion. Of course, it is difficult to forecast when the market will turn around. Still, when a reversal occurs in the context of crowded call buying, market makers who had bought spot stocks for delta-hedging are forced to shift to selling, likely amplifying the reversal's magnitude. In addition, we should keep in mind that CTA positioning has also shifted toward reducing global equity longs ("natural position").

Higher yields are potential trigger for reversal / Pause in AI stock selection and rebound in value / Concerns about sharp rise in yen rates among bank investors / Rise in inflation expectations and consumer spending-related stocks

What could trigger an increase in reversals in the current phase? As in the past, yields are the most likely candidate. Globally, yields are again accelerating upward, led by Japan and the UK. 30yr UST yields have clearly surpassed 5.0%, which had been seen as the upper bound. Should the pause in AI-driven stock selection continue, Japanese equities' value factor rebound is likely to persist (*Figure 4*). Value buying is also expanding within the domestic demand universe (*Figure 5*; for details, see our 11 May 2026 report *Nomura Quant Insights - Near-term overheating signs for AI-driven US equities vs scope for more FOMO among foreigners in Korean equities*). While bank stocks are still lagging markedly behind, their outperformance on investment profitability factors continues (*Figure 6*, *Figure 7*). Compared with the recent rise in yen interest rates, we think there is still room for further growth. As with the bond market, we think this demonstrates deep-rooted concerns among bank stock investors about the risk of a sharp rise in yen interest rates (*Figure 8*). Higher inflation expectations in Japan continue to hurt consumer spending-related stocks (*Figure 9*). Despite the rise in inflation expectations in the reversal-driven market in Nov–Dec last year, there was no rotation.

Normalization of Strait of Hormuz also a potential reversal catalyst / Iran war losers could recover as situation normalizes / Japanese defense-related stocks solid

The situation in the Middle East also remains important. While the US-China summit led to

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no progress, there is still a possibility that the China-Russia summit on 19-20 May could act as a catalyst. If it looks like the Strait of Hormuz will normalize, we expect profit-taking on AI-related stocks to increase, partly because they had been seen as default safe haven buys due to low Middle East exposure. Conversely, stocks that have been losers in the Iran war are highly likely to see a recovery (for details, see our 11 May 2026 report *Nomura Quant Insights - Near-term overheating signs for AI-driven US equities vs scope for more FOMO among foreigners in Korean equities*). We see scope for a recovery not only in Japanese equities but also in Asian equities overall (*Figure 10*). We think investors should consider buying defense-related stocks on the dip. While it is true that profit-taking selling is increasing in Europe and the US, Japan may remain supported on “buy the dip” flows ahead of the June Basic Policy (*Figure 11*). Last week the market rebounded to excess return levels comparable to last December. This is a strong signal that they are unlikely to return to the levels seen before the Takaichi administration took office.

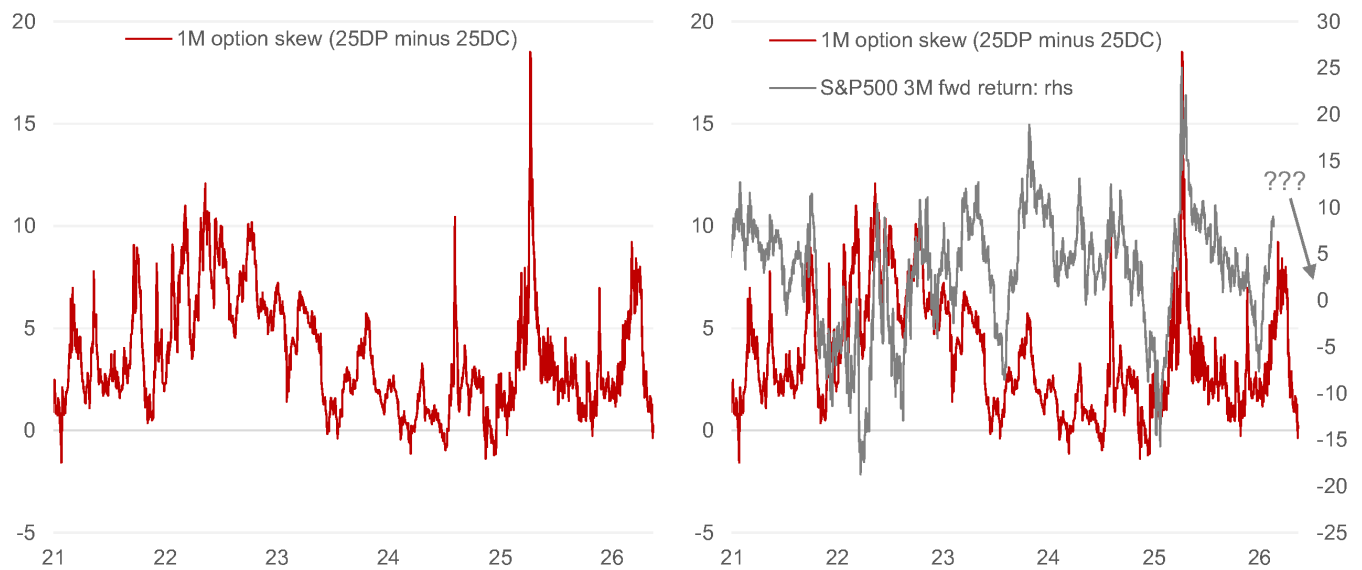
Response to Nvidia results and drift effect / Focus on breakeven lines in options market / CTAs begin reducing longs on Japanese equities / Slightly short gamma

We expect attention to focus on Nvidia's results announcement slated for 20 May. While less impactful than in the past, we note that outsized positive or negative price reactions relative to option market expectations tend to generate a short-term price drift across tech stocks as a whole (see our 24 February 2026 report *Nomura Quant Insights - Tariff policy uncertainty and the risk of more flight from USD / Tech earnings and breakeven lines*; *Figure 12*). Current breakeven levels imply stocks could swing around 4–5% in either direction, albeit with fluctuation along the way. Should Nvidia's share price drop by more than 5% immediately after the results announcement, it could trigger widespread unwinding of bullish tech positions. The degree of return dispersion is also useful in gauging the magnitude of reversals (three-month return is particularly effective; *Figure 13*). While this dispersion is currently slightly lower than it was in October 2025, it has risen sharply and is already above a 3-sigma move (*Figure 14*). Another reversal of around 6–7% would not be out of the question (*Figure 15*). However, it is notable that CTAs have already started to reduce their long positions on Japanese equity (for details, see our 11 May 2026 report *Nomura Quant Insights - Near-term overheating signs for AI-driven US equities vs scope for more FOMO among foreigners in Korean equities*). We estimate that net long exposure to Japanese equities currently amounts to around ¥1trn. We think it will be somewhat more difficult for CTAs to start adding to their long positions again (*Figure 16*). Market makers' gamma exposure has flipped to the short side, but the magnitude of that shift is very small (*Figure 17*).

Reference figures

Fig. 1: Relationship between option skew in the Magnificent 7 stocks and US equity market returns

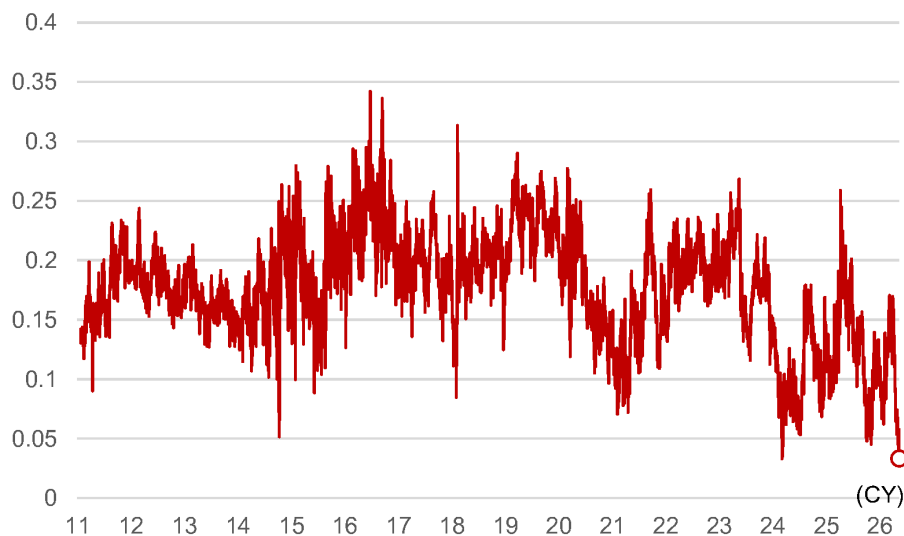
Option skew for the Mag7 turned negative last week, the first time since Oct 2025. A decline in this skew tends to weigh on future US equity returns.



Source: Nomura, based on Bloomberg data

Fig. 2: Skew for US high-tech stocks (tech skew)

Sharp decline to near historic lows

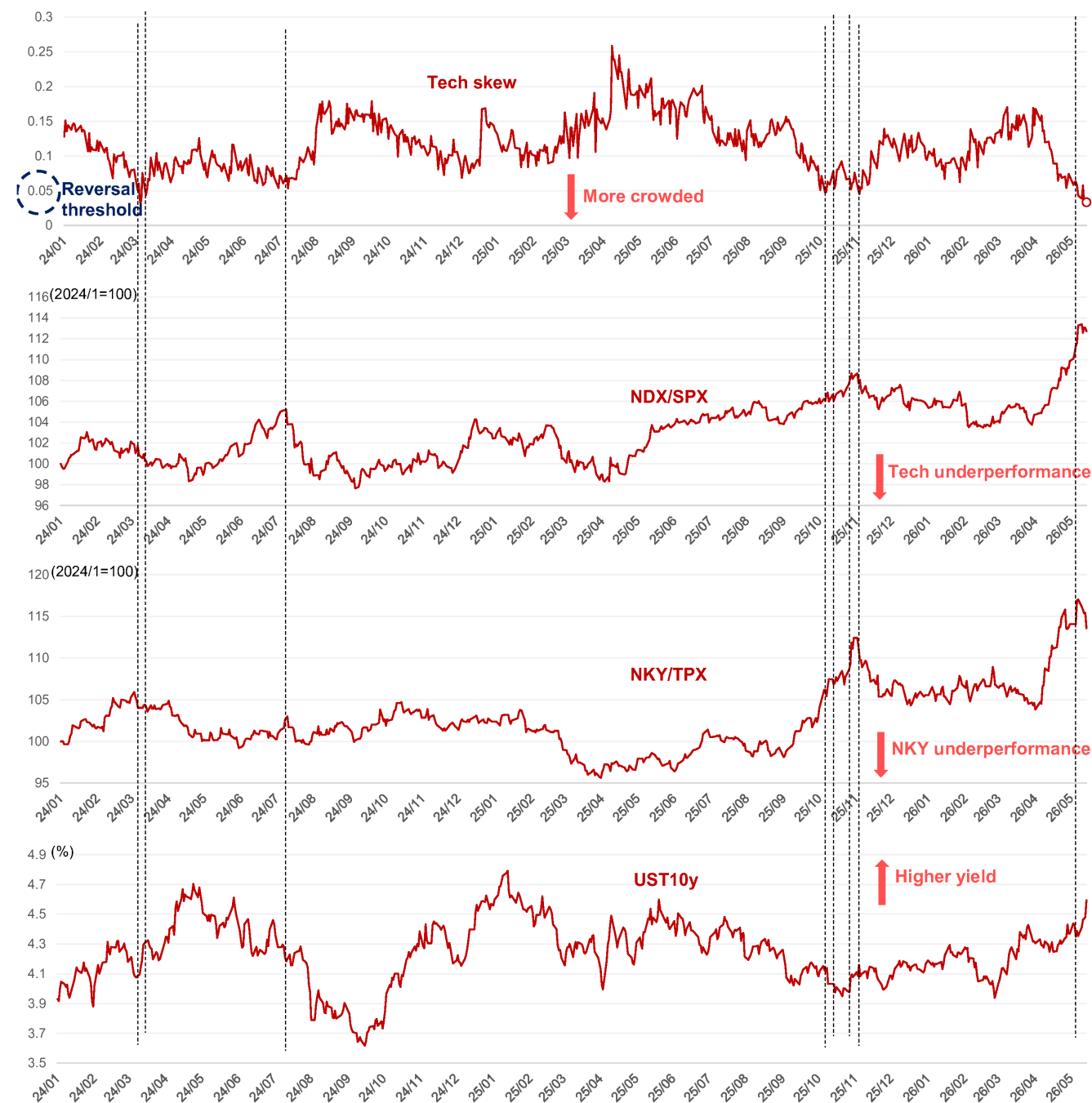


Note: Simple average skew based on one-month forward implied volatility for each of the constituents of the Technology Select Sector SPDR Fund (XLK). Skew calculated as spread between puts and calls divided by at-the-money price. Latest value shown as a white circle.

Source: Nomura, based on Bloomberg data

Fig. 3: Tech skew as a reversal indicator

Since 2023, whenever the tech skew has dropped below 0.05 during the AI rally, a reversal has followed 100% of the time. The direct triggers are all macroeconomic events linked to US interest rates.

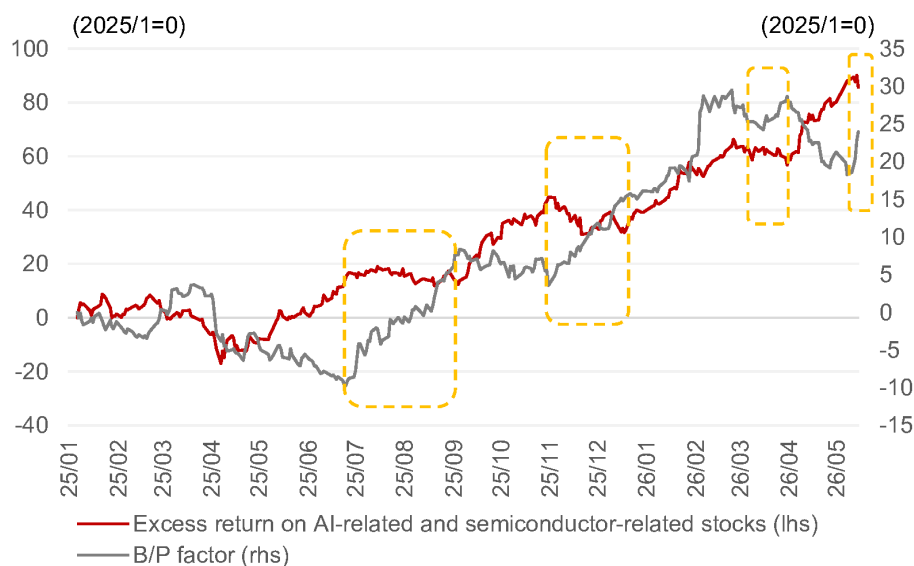


Note: Periods when the tech skew dropped below 0.05 are indicated here (excluding the most recent data).

Source: Nomura, based on Bloomberg data

Fig. 4: Japanese equities: Excess return on AI-related and semiconductor-related stocks vs the value factor

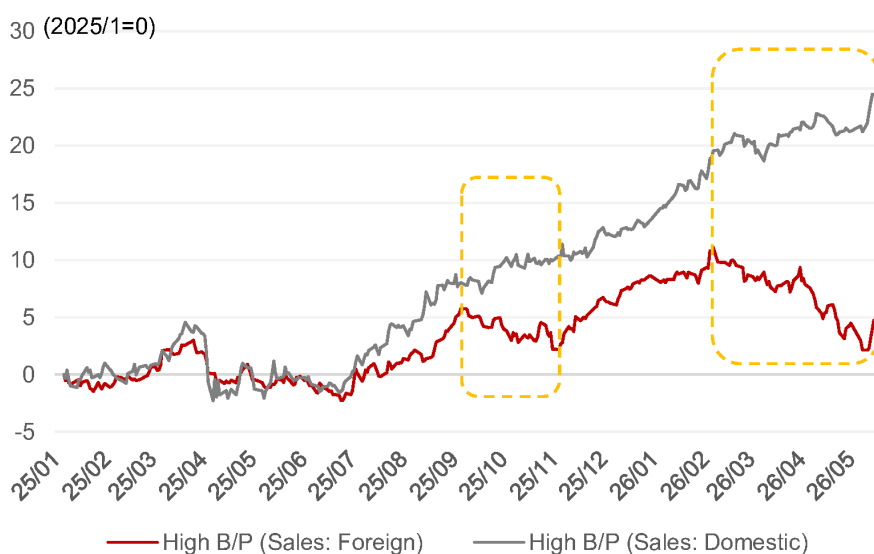
Value tends to recover when tech stocks stop rising



Source: Nomura, based on Bloomberg data

Fig. 5: Excess return on high-B/P stocks within the TOPIX 500 universes of domestic demand stocks and external demand stocks

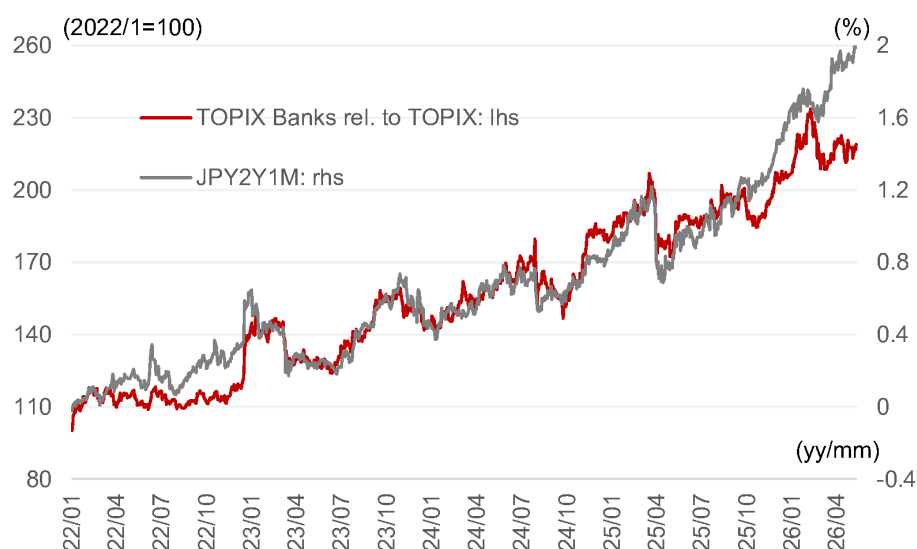
During the tech-led market phases of Sep-Oct 2025 and now, value stocks have underperformed substantially within the universe of external demand stocks, but have continued to find favor within the universe of domestic demand stocks.



Source: Nomura, based on Bloomberg data

Fig. 6: TOPIX bank stocks vs the pricing in of BOJ rate hikes

Bank stocks faring much worse than one would expect based on market-implied BOJ rate hike expectations



Source: Nomura, based on Bloomberg data

Fig. 7: Investment profitability factor for TOPIX bank stocks vs 10yr JGB yield

Outperformance in line with previous increases in yen interest rates, suggesting further upside remains

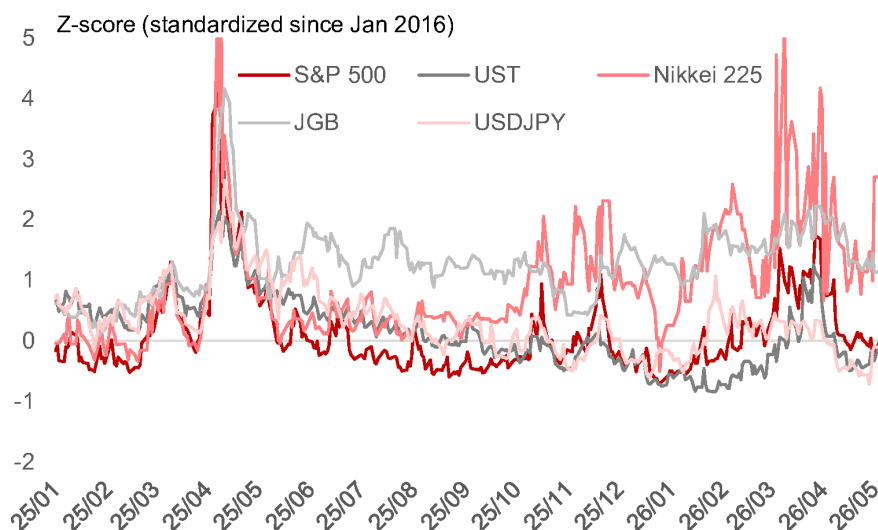


Note: Measure of investment profitability used for the investment profitability factor is net unrealized gains/losses on marketable securities + deferred gains/losses on hedges + shareholders' equity. Factor performance measured as the spread return between the top 30% and the bottom 30% (rebalanced at the end of each month).

Source: Nomura, based on Bloomberg data

Fig. 8: One-month forward implied volatility comparison

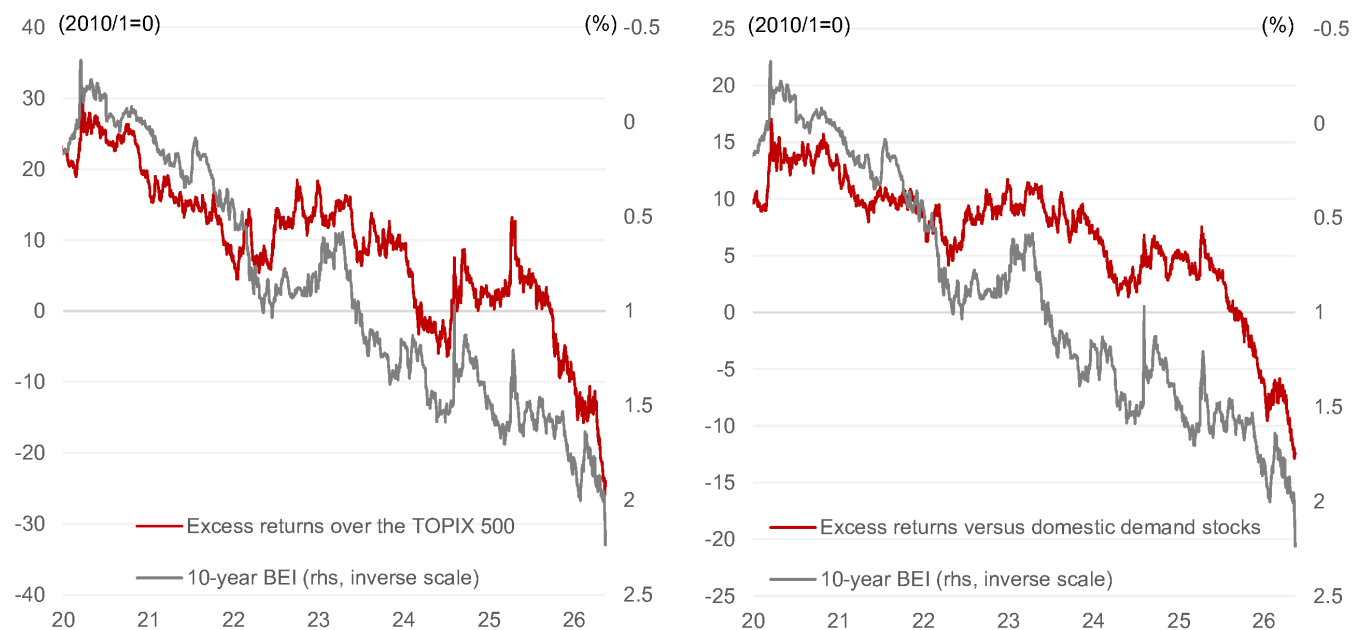
Marked rise in yen interest rate volatility recently



Source: Nomura, based on Bloomberg data

Fig. 9: Excess returns on consumer spending-related stocks vs Japanese inflation expectations

They consistently underperformed even as inflation expectations strengthened. There was no rotation in the reversal-driven market in Nov–Dec last year.

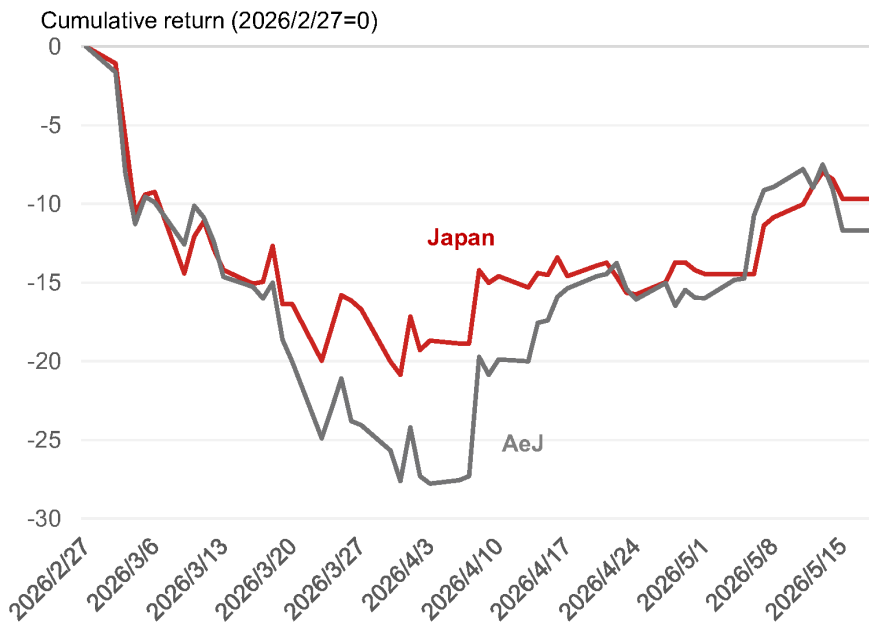


Note: Domestic demand stocks defined as the stocks of companies that record at least 50% of their companywide sales in Japan. We then extracted from that list the stocks that are counted as consumption-related in the GICS sector classifications.

Source: Nomura, based on Bloomberg data

Fig. 10: Share price returns on stocks negatively affected by Iran conflict in Japanese and Asian markets

Still room for a rebound

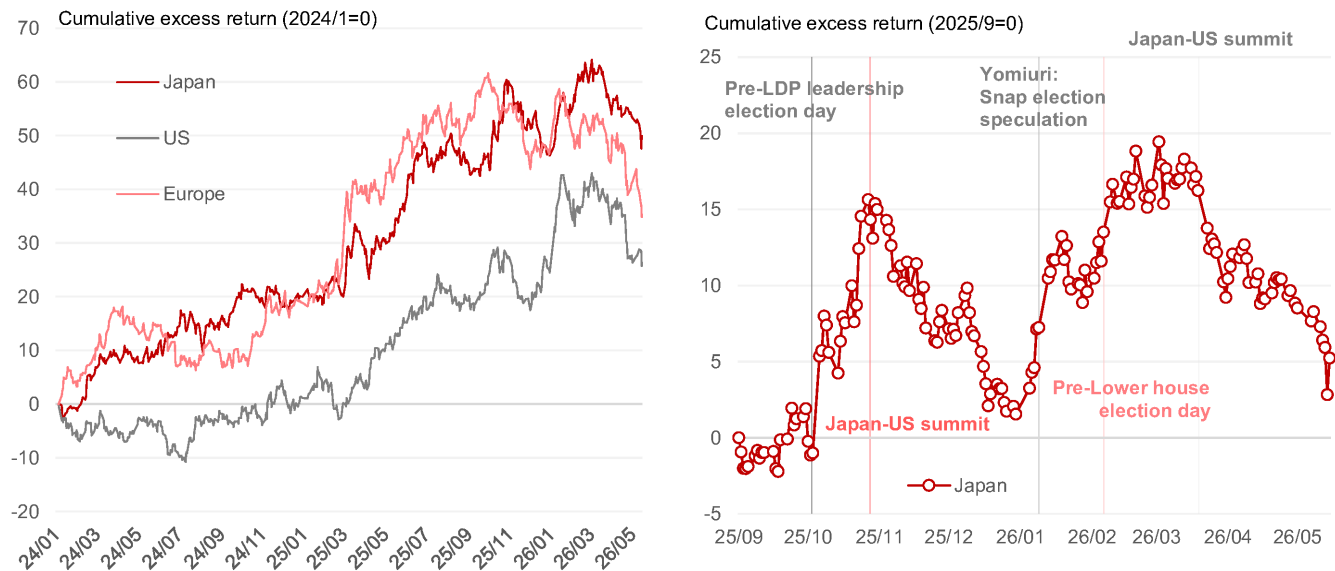


Note: See 11 May 2026 Quant Insights report for details.

Source: Nomura, based on Bloomberg data

Fig. 11: Excess returns on defense-related stocks in Japan, the US, and Europe

Japanese defense-related stocks have been performing better than their US and European counterparts, rebounding to excess return levels comparable to December last year. This is a strong signal that they are unlikely to return to the levels seen before the Takaichi administration took office.

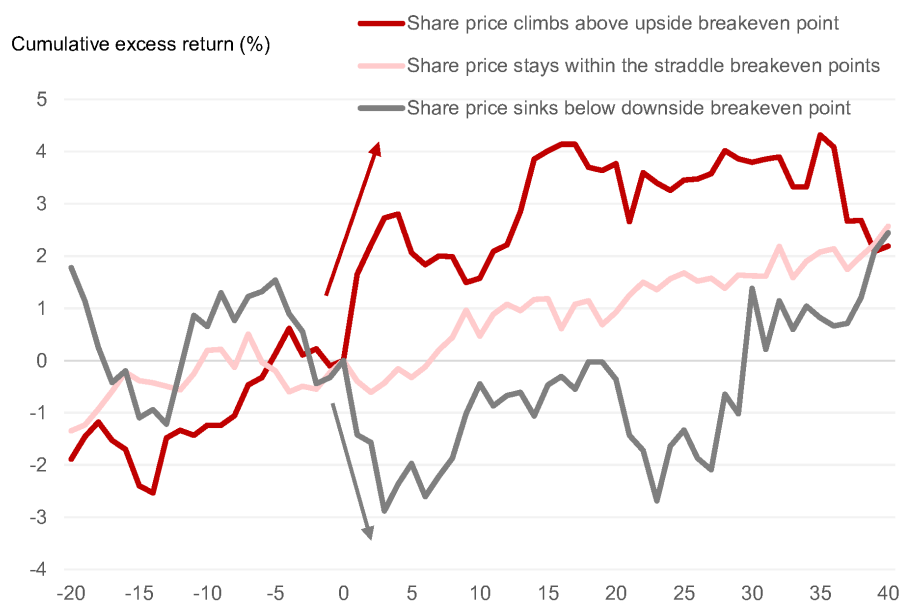


Note: Benchmarks are the TOPIX, S&P 500, and STOXX 600.

Source: Nomura, based on Bloomberg data

Fig. 12: Excess return on US tech stocks, grouped by share price reaction to Nvidia earnings surprises

Tech stocks in general tend to experience a short-term post-announcement drift effect

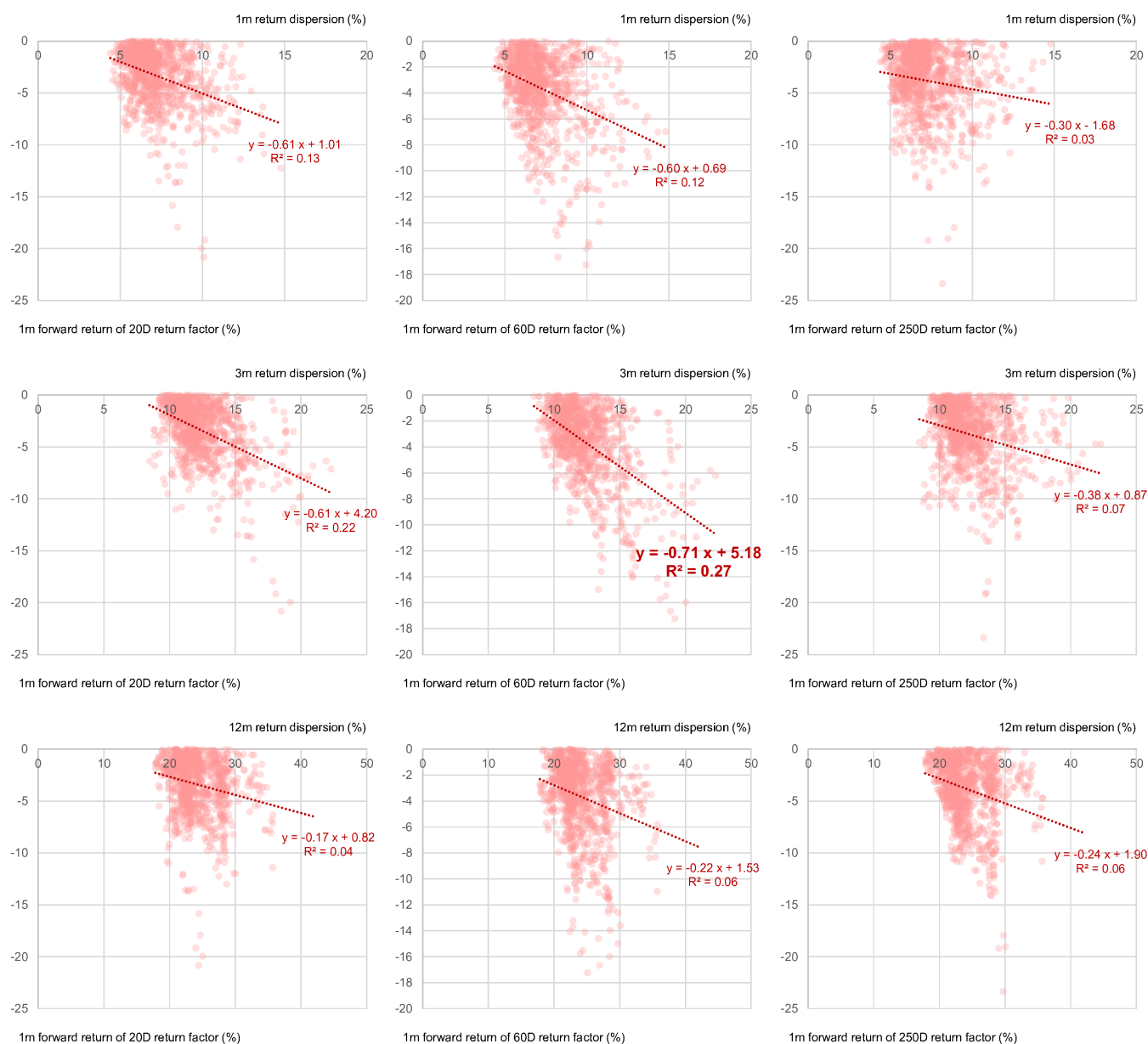


Note: Breakeven points calculated from straddles covering the date of Nvidia's earnings announcement. Sample period is May 2023 to present.

Source: Nomura, based on Bloomberg data

Fig. 13: Dispersion of returns and magnitude of reversals when momentum factor performance is in a correction phase

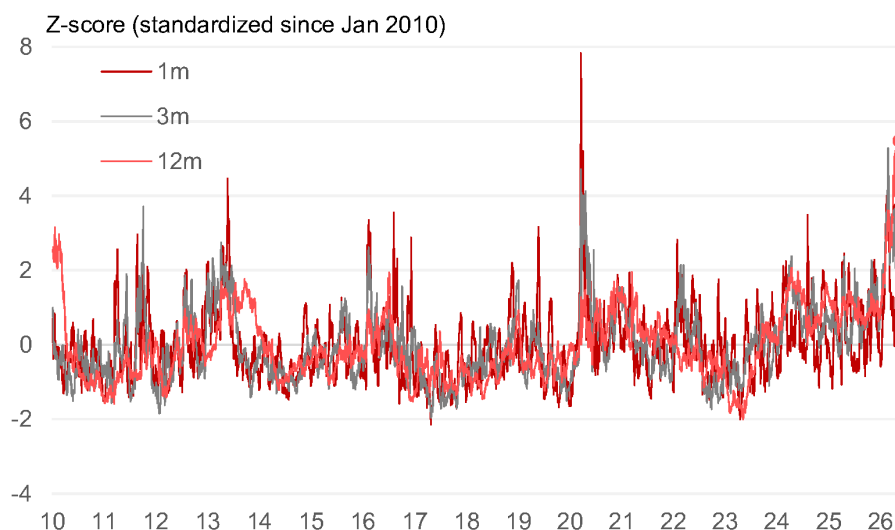
Relatively strong correlation between three-month return dispersion and reversals in the same factor



Note: Compares return dispersion and subsequent one-month returns of the momentum factor. From top, return dispersion over past one, three and 12 months; from left, subsequent one-month returns of price return factors for past one, three and 12 months. Period of analysis is 2010 to the present. Universe is TOPIX 500 constituents.

Source: Nomura, based on Bloomberg data

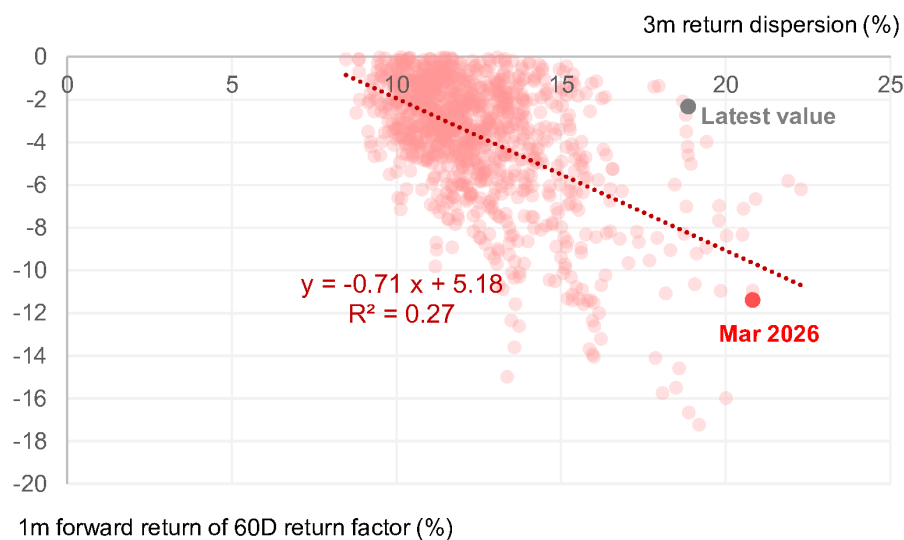
Fig. 14: Return dispersion for TOPIX 500 stocks



Source: Nomura, based on Bloomberg data

Fig. 15: Dispersion of returns and magnitude of reversals when momentum factor performance is in a correction phase

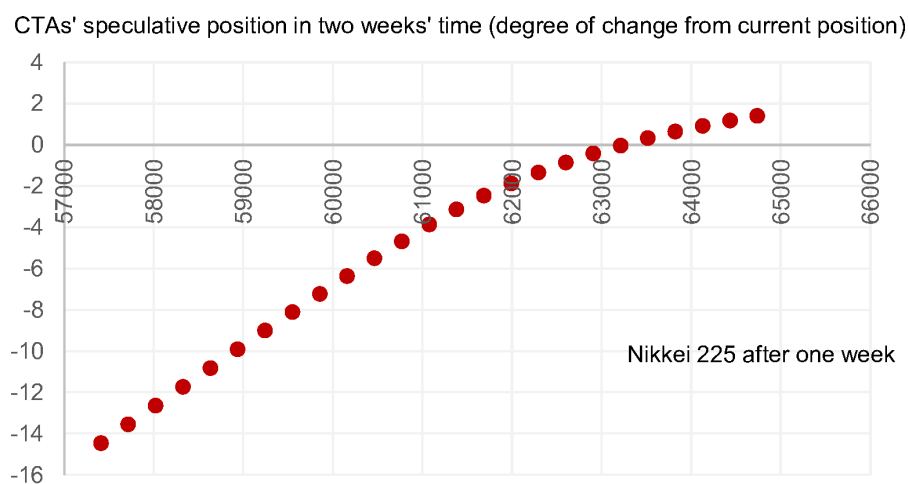
Another reversal of around 6–7% would not be out of the question



Note: Sample period is 2010 to the present. Universe is TOPIX 500 constituents.

Source: Nomura, based on Bloomberg data

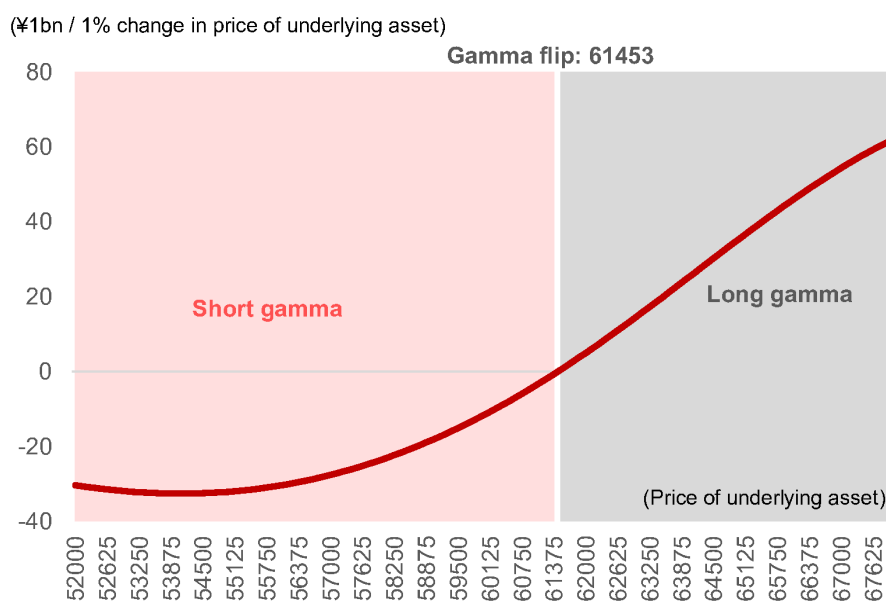
Fig. 16: Estimates of CTAs' speculative position two weeks later for a range of Nikkei 225 readings one week later



Note: We estimate CTAs' "natural" position after two weeks based on share price levels after one week. CTAs' speculative positions are relative to the historical peaks in both long and short positions since 2000 (peak = 100). "Natural" position is our estimate of how CTAs' aggregate net position would change over the next four weeks if the spot price were to remain constant. Data current through 15 May 2026.

Source: Nomura, based on Bloomberg data

Fig. 17: Dealers' gamma exposure in the Nikkei 225 options market (estimated)



Note: Estimates of how dealers' gamma position changes as price of underlying asset changes, covering all unexpired call and put options. The gamma flip is the price of the underlying asset at which dealers' gamma position flips from positive to negative or vice versa.

Source: Nomura, based on Bloomberg data

Appendix: CTAs' speculative positions

Fig. 18: Estimates of CTAs' speculative positions in major asset classes

Asset		CTAs' speculative position			Change in the "natural" position over time (ppt change from the estimated current position)				Chart
		Latest		1 week ago	1 week from now	2 weeks from now	3 weeks from now	4 weeks from now	
Equity	S&P500		19%	16%	-3.5	-4.1	-5.2	-6.2	
	NASDAQ100		21%	16%	-3.3	-4.9	-6.4	-7.3	
	Nikkei225		20%	22%	-3.6	-5.2	-6.5	-8.4	
	STOXX50		1%	4%	-4.2	-10.3	-13.5	-13.9	
	FTSE100		3%	6%	-6.8	-14.0	-19.2	-22.5	
Bond	UST10y	-9%		-6%	-4.5	-9.3	-15.3	-14.5	
	UST2y	-13%		-9%	-5.6	-11.5	-16.6	-14.9	
	JGB	-70%		-60%	-7.6	-12.9	-21.7	-21.3	
	Bund	-7%		-6%	-4.1	-9.6	-12.8	-16.1	
	Gilt	-28%		-24%	-5.3	-11.5	-15.0	-14.8	
Forex	EUR/USD	-2%		3%	-3.9	-5.5	-8.1	-7.8	
	USD/JPY		0%	1%	-1.0	-2.6	-2.2	-1.5	
	GBP/USD	-1%		12%	-4.6	-7.0	-11.7	-15.0	
	USD/CAD	-13%		-10%	2.1	5.0	9.5	13.6	
	AUD/USD		20%	25%	-2.0	-2.4	-0.3	0.0	
	NZD/USD		2%	8%	-3.3	-5.0	-7.3	-9.2	
	USD/CHF	-4%		-9%	5.1	8.7	13.7	16.6	
	USD/NOK	-30%		-34%	5.8	5.9	6.3	5.4	
	USD/SEK		3%	-6%	5.8	12.0	16.3	17.0	
Commodity	Brent		56%	50%	10.3	11.4	4.5	0.2	

Note: "Natural" position is our estimate of how CTAs' aggregate net position would change over the next four weeks if the spot price were to remain constant. Current as of 15 May 2026.

Source: Nomura, based on Bloomberg data

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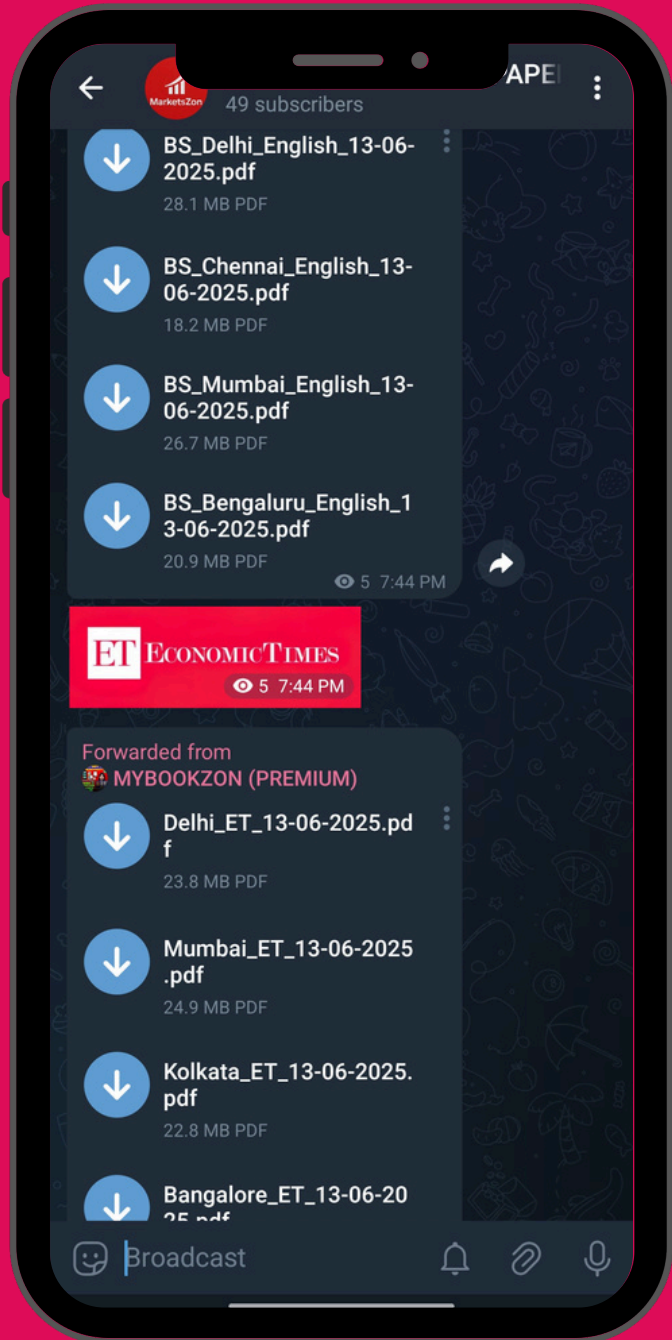
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